8.6 WHO and Trump

The WHO possesses characteristics that, in many ways, make it a prime target for populist opposition. Staffed by international experts such as scientists and public health professionals, it operates in the realm of scientific data and health policy, areas often viewed skeptically by populists (as we showed in chapter 3). Its work inherently involves constraining state sovereignty, as member states are required to provide sensitive information on disease outbreaks, public health data, and vaccine research. The WHO's recommendations, ranging from quarantines to travel bans, can impose significant logistical, economic, and political challenges on nations. These measures, while essential for global health, are often resisted, particularly by populist leaders who view such constraints as infringements on national autonomy (Carnegie and Carson 2023).

Donald Trump was an especially vocal critic of the WHO during his first term as US president, accusing it of bias toward China and pointing to what he labeled as "faulty recommendations" during the COVID-19 pandemic.[59] In April 2020, his administration thus announced a temporary suspension of US funding to the organization. By July of that year, the administration formally notified the United Nations of its intent to withdraw from the WHO entirely. Trump's criticism, amplified through social media, significantly undermined the organization, which depended heavily on US contributions for funding and on its engagement for legitimacy. For instance, the CDC and WHO have a long history of working together to address global health crises, such as Ebola outbreaks in sub-Saharan Africa. Echoing populist rhetoric, Trump administration officials framed their opposition in terms of safeguarding US sovereignty, rejecting the constraints the WHO was perceived to impose.[60]

The WHO responded to these challenges using strategies that aligned with its broader approach to populist opposition. To mitigate the damage from the US withdrawal, the WHO focused on carrying out its core functions—data collection, research, and pandemic response—by leveraging collaborations with other member states and IOs (Kuznetsova 2020). It coordinated efforts with partners such as UN agencies (e.g., UNICEF) and other global health organizations, ensuring a steady flow of expertise and resources. The Access to COVID-19 Tools (ACT) Accelerator